



[OGS \(HTTPS://INTERNATIONAL.NORTHEASTERN.EDU/OGS\)](https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs)



Students Studying in The United States

APPLYING FOR F-1 POST- COMPLETION OPT



F-1 students may apply to USCIS for Post-Completion Optional Practical Training (OPT) work authorization, which helps them apply their classroom learning to the real-world.

RECENT USCIS POLICY UPDATES

Last Updated January 30, 2026 (<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/uscis-policy-changes/>)

WHAT IS OPT?

Post-Completion Optional Practical Training (Post-OPT) is a type of employment authorization adjudicated by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). It is available to eligible F-1 students for the purpose of gaining practical experience directly related to their program of study. A Post-OPT application first requires an OPT recommendation on a student's Form I-20, then a timely application to USCIS for final adjudication. If successful, USCIS will issue an Employment Authorization Document (EAD).

ELIGIBILITY

Students may apply for a maximum of 12-months of Post-Completion OPT upon completion of each higher degree level. Only one Post-Completion OPT application is allowed per academic degree level (i.e. Bachelor's, Master's, PhD).

You may apply for Post-Completion OPT only if all of the following criteria have been met:

- You have maintained a valid F-1 student status
- You have been enrolled full-time for at least one academic year
- You have completed fewer than 365 days of full-time Curricular Practical Training (CPT) at the degree level for which you are applying for OPT
- You have completed all coursework (may be in final stages of thesis/dissertation)
- You are inside the U.S.

Note: If you depart the U.S. before your OPT application has been filed, received and receipted by the USCIS, you become ineligible to apply for Post-Completion OPT if your program has ended.

Important Considerations for Students with Pending Pre-OPT Applications

- OGS generally advises against applying for post-OPT while a pre-OPT application is still pending with USCIS.

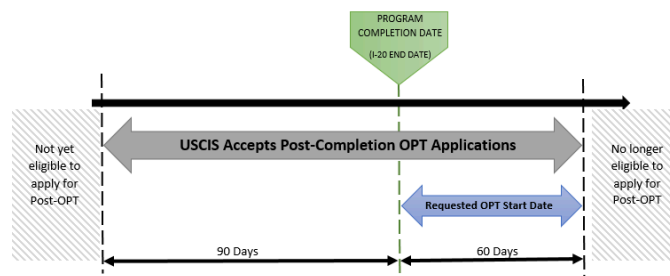
If you choose to apply for post-OPT anyway, you should first request to withdraw your pre-OPT application to avoid delays or processing errors. Having two OPT applications pending at the same time can lead to significant USCIS delays or incorrect EAD dates, since any approved pre-OPT time must be deducted from post-OPT.

- > If your pre-OPT adjudication is delayed and you want to withdraw the application, see the instructions [opt%2F&data=05%7C02%7Cr.hollabaugh%40northeastern.edu%7Ced001d459cec4a0fdda00](#)
- > If you request an OPT recommendation I-20 while your pre-OPT is still pending, and OGS advisor will contact you to confirm you understand the risks with having multiple pending USCIS applications.

APPLICATION TIMELINE

You may apply to USCIS for Post-Completion OPT work authorization no earlier than 90 days prior to your program completion date. Post-OPT applications cannot be submitted to USCIS later than 60 days after the program completion date (i.e. during the 60-day grace period).

OPT Application Timeline



Important reminder about Your Program Completion Date

The program end date on your I-20 is an estimated program end date, which may be different from your actual program end date. You must apply for OPT based on your last registered term. For immigration purposes, program completion date corresponds with the last term of enrollment, not necessarily the date of the graduation ceremony or degree conferral date.

For example, if you finish all of your courses in May, but your degree conferral is in August, your I-20 end date will be a May date if you have no registration over the summer.

PhD student Program Completion Dates

Students in the PhD program may choose the date of completion based on any of the following dates:

- > Dissertation defense date, or
- > Dissertation/correction submission date, or
- > End of last registered term

CHOOSING YOUR START DATE

If you have not used any Pre-Completion OPT time, you may request up to 12-months of Post-Completion OPT. You must request a start date within the 60-day grace period of your program. You select your own start and end date for OPT (even if you do not yet have a job offer).

Here are some general suggestions to help you make the best decision for your situation:

- > If you have a job offer and your job starts during your 60-day grace period, use the job start date (or earlier) as your requested start of OPT
- > If you have a job offer and it starts after your 60-day grace period, use the latest date possible (59th day of grace period) for your OPT start date



Picking Your Start Date



Choosing an Earlier OPT Start Date



Your employer will be impressed that you can start your new job so quickly

If you don't find a job quickly, you may risk being unemployed for 90 days and would need to leave the U.S.



Choosing a Later OPT Start Date



You have less of a chance to be unemployed for 90 days and be required to leave the U.S.

A job offer could be rescinded if your employment start date is uncertain or too far in the future



Mailing Your Application to USCIS

Points to consider if you want to send your OPT application to USCIS...

...near your program end date

-Or-

...during your grace period

to postpone your OPT start date as late as possible



You will have extra time to find a job



You may not receive all 12 months of OPT (OPT end date must be within 14 months of program end date)



Your OPT start date will be uncertain – OPT start date will be the date of approval, not your requested start date



Job offer may be rescinded because of long wait time

Reminder: Students are not eligible to begin working until the Post-OPT has been approved by USCIS, they have received their EAD, **and** the start date on the EAD has arrived.

NOTE FOR PHD STUDENTS

If a PhD student has completed all their coursework but is in the final stages of thesis/dissertation, immigration regulations allow the student to apply for either Pre-Completion OPT or Post-Completion OPT while completing their thesis/dissertation.

In this case, the PhD student and their college need to determine the end date of program completion, and the student's I-20 will be updated to reflect it as the completion date of the program.

If you choose to apply for Post-Completion OPT while completing thesis/dissertation:

- > You must fulfill the reporting requirements of Post-Completion OPT
- > Days you do not have a job count toward 90 days of unemployment time
- > You cannot request program extension even if your thesis/dissertation is not completed after Post-Completion OPT is expired

OGS AND USCIS APPLICATION PROCESS

(For more information, click each step below)

- + **Step 1: Log in to myOGS**
- + **Step 2: Complete the Post-OPT Quiz**
- + **Step 3: Submit the Post-OPT I-20 Request to OGS**
- + **Step 4: Prepare your OPT Application for USCIS**
- + **Step 5: (Optional) Premium Processing**
- + **Step 6: Attend a Biometrics Appointment (if scheduled)**

Do Not Travel Abroad While Your Application is Pending with USCIS

You may be scheduled for a required in-person biometrics appointment — missing it will result in denial of your application. Additionally, your EAD can only be mailed to a U.S. address, and you cannot re-enter the U.S. without it.

AFTER YOU SUBMIT TO USCIS

Remember, you must not begin working until you have your physical Employment Authorization Document (EAD) in hand!

- + Receipt Notice (Form I-797) and Waiting Period**
- + Premium Processing**
- + Do Not Travel While Your Application is Pending**
- + Updating Your Address with USCIS**

APPLICATION OUTCOMES

- + Post-OPT Approved**
- + Received a Request for Evidence (RFE) , Notice of Intent to Deny (NOID), or Notice of Intent to Revoke (NOIR)**
- + Post-OPT Denied**

RESOLVING COMMON OPT AND STEM APPLICATION AND EAD

ISSUES

Problems or Issues with your OPT/STEM OPT application or EAD card(s)? Check out our knowledge base article on how to resolve common OPT/STEM OPT application and EAD card issues.

[Click Here \(https://northeastern.service-now.com/kb_view.do?sysparm_article=KB000023648\)](https://northeastern.service-now.com/kb_view.do?sysparm_article=KB000023648)

IMPORTANT REMINDERS

- > Do not submit an OPT application to USCIS before receiving an OPT recommendation on your I-20
- > USCIS must receive the OPT application within 30 days of date that OPT was recommended by OGS; if the application is not received by USCIS within 30 days of the OPT recommendation, your application will be denied
- > Do not wait for a job offer in order to start the OPT application process
- > Students must abide by all reporting requirements while on Post-Completion OPT.
(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/reporting-post-opt/>)

Exceeding Unemployment During Post-OPT

If employment is not updated in the SEVP Portal within 90 days of the start date on your EAD card, or you accrue more than 90 days of unemployment during your Post-OPT period, your SEVIS record may be automatically terminated. It is your responsibility to keep a personal record of all OPT activity.

RESPONSIBILITIES DURING POST-OPT

+ **Reporting Employment during Post-OPT**

+ **Traveling during Post-OPT**

+ **Studying during Post-OPT**

RELATED ARTICLES:

Form I-765 Supplemental Guide

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/off-campus-employment/form-i-765-supplemental-guide/>)

USCIS Case Evidence Request

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/forms-and-guides/uscis-case-evidence-request/>)

Reporting Post-Completion OPT

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/reporting-post-opt/>)

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[OGS Service Portal](https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs) (<https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs>)

OFFICE HOURS

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-5:00p.m.

(Note: We are closed on Tuesdays from 3:00pm – 4:00pm for all staff training and meeting).

Phone Hours:

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.–4:30p.m. ET

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